[3]
The Media Constructs a Kashmiri Terrorist

Syed Bismillah Geelani

Between 16 December and 23 December 2001, the investigating agencies and the media constructed an image of my brother as an archetypal Kashmiri terrorist. This is the image that I believe condemned him to death even before the sessions court trial began. That is the image that has come to stay, even though the Delhi High Court and the Supreme Court have acquitted him.

The *Hindustan Times* announced on 16 December 2001: 'Case Cracked: Jaish behind attack'. The story was written by Arun Joshi and Neeta Sharma from Jammu and New Delhi.

I quote verbatim the first three paragraphs of the report:

> The Delhi police have claimed that Special Cell investigators probing Thursday's attack on the Parliament House Complex have cracked the case.
>
> In Delhi, the Special Cell detectives detained a lecturer in Arabic, who teaches in Zakir Hussain (evening) College of Delhi University, after it was established that he had received a call made by the militants on his mobile phone (cash card no. 0811641893). The lecturer, Abdul Ahmed Jelani, allegedly also spoke to some people in Pakistan. The agencies believe that he spoke to militants belonging to the Jaish-e-Mohammed. They also claim that Jelani is related to a Kashmiri separatist leader based in London.
>
> Under interrogation, Jelani named two people in Kashmir—Ashfaq and Shaukat—as the two key planners of the operation. Police sources say that the explosives used in the operation were transported to Delhi in trucks owned by them.[1]

In this six-column bottom-spread there is a small box entitled 'The Usual Suspect', with a photo of Maulana Masood Azhar and a line on my brother: 'A Delhi lecturer, who spoke to militants, also called up Jaish militants in Pakistan.' In another news item (in a long single column) entitled 'Past 24 Hours', the first item is again on Geelani:

> A Zakir Hussain (evening) College lecturer, Abdul Ahmed Jelani, detained after a call from the militants' mobile phone is traced to his mobile. Terrorists spoke to him before the attack and the lecturer made a phone call to Pakistan after the strike.[2]